technologically sophisticated but defensively oriented military and no historical disputes with India – makes strategic sense. Japan, for its part, has sought new partners in Asia as the end of the Cold War has brought forth the respective spectres of China's rise, North Korea's belligerence, South Korea's calculated indifference, and the United States' unreliability as an ally. A deeper relationship with India – the world's third-largest economy (in PPP terms) with a large and well-resourced military and nuclear weapons – also makes strategic sense for Tokyo.

Compatible interests alone, however, do not guarantee a strong partnership. And if the periodic proclamations of India's and Japan's leaders are anything to go by, their strategic embrace is set to become "the most important bilateral relationship in the world."[10] What, then, explains the importance that India and Japan give each other? For the purpose of this chapter, why did India specifically single out Japan as a major partner? This question is especially pertinent in the context of oft-repeated arguments about India's "Look East" (now "Act East") policy driving its engagement with Japan. Early in his Prime Ministership, Narendra Modi emphasised Japan's place "at the heart of India's Look East Policy."[11] Looking or Acting East, however, remains a policy and still begs the question of why India might look East and in particular single out Japan as a close partner. India's eastward focus is driven not only by a desire to tap into Asia's economic vibrancy but also to develop strategic partnerships that might assist India diplomatically in its regional rivalry with China. However, a desire to look East does not explain the extent to which India has developed its partnership with Japan compared to Korea, Australia, or the ASEAN countries. In fact, a close embrace of Japan could arguably alienate some East Asian and Southeast Asian nations that harbour historical resentments against Japan for its actions in the Second World War. The